Abstract

Prior research finds that disclosing one's own prosocial behavior can carry moral reputational costs. We argue that this effect depends on both the type of prosocial act being disclosed and the circumstances surrounding the act. Across five preregistered experiments (total $N = 3{,}979$), we compare prosocial actors' disclosure of their own helping acts with disclosure of their own acts of third-party punishment. We find that disclosing one's own helping acts reliably increases perceived self-promotion and lowers moral reputation. In contrast, disclosing one's own third-party punishments produces weaker self-promotion inferences and stronger inferences that the actor is trying to inform others about a threat. These motive attributions help explain why disclosure harms moral reputation less after third-party punishment than after helping. In some cases, third-party punishment disclosure can even improve moral reputation, particularly when the disclosed incident communicates information about a threat that is highly relevant to the audience. Thus, the present research advances a deeper understanding of the moral reputational consequences of disclosing prosocial behavior, demonstrating that this effect depends not only on whether actors choose to disclose, but also on the type of disclosed act and features of its context, which together shape the motives observers attribute to disclosure decisions.

Keywords: third-party punishment, self-promotion, moral reputation

Imagine that just before arriving at work, Sam sees a stranger attempting to steal someone else's bicycle. Sam confronts the stranger firmly and directly, and the stranger flees without stealing the bicycle. Sam then enters the office and bumps into a group of colleagues. How would telling colleagues about this incident affect Sam's reputation?

Sam's behavior may have been confrontational, but it was also prosocial. By intervening, Sam protected another person's property and upheld a widely-shared norm against theft. More specifically, Sam's behavior can be described as an act of third-party punishment: a form of prosocial behavior that involves incurring a cost to punish someone who has violated a norm, even though the norm violation did not directly harm the punisher (Fehr & Fischbacher, 2004).

Prior research suggests that telling others about one's own prosocial behavior carries risk for moral reputation. Such disclosure can undermine moral reputation because observers may interpret it as an attempt to reap the reputational benefits associated with being seen as moral (Berman et al., 2015; Carlson et al., 2022; De Freitas et al., 2019). In contrast, refraining from telling others about one's own prosocial acts is often seen as being particularly moral (Berman et al., 2015; De Freitas et al., 2019). Thus, existing research suggests that Sam may face reputational costs for telling others about what he did.

Yet this literature has focused on the reputational consequences of disclosing acts of *helping* (e.g., Berman et al., 2015; De Freitas et al., 2019; Silver & Small, 2024), which involve directly providing benefits to others rather than punishing unethical perpetrators. It remains unclear whether disclosing other forms of prosocial behavior—specifically third-party punishment—carries the same moral reputational costs.

In the present research, we argue that existing literature on disclosing one's own prosocial behavior captures only part of the broader moral reputation dynamics, owing to its focus on helping disclosure. Implicit in this literature is the assumption that disclosing prosocial behavior is viewed suspiciously by others—as an attempt to obtain the reputational benefits associated with being seen as moral. However, different forms of prosocial behavior vary in systematic ways that challenge the generality of this assumption.

We examine this possibility by contrasting disclosure choices about helping and third-party punishment. We propose that, because these forms of prosocial behavior signal different traits about actors and tend to occur in different contexts, their disclosure triggers different motive attributions. Specifically, helping disclosure (versus remaining silent) should more strongly increase perceptions of self-promotion than third-party punishment disclosure. Furthermore, third-party punishment disclosure (versus remaining silent) should more strongly increase perceptions of a motive to inform others about threats associated with the unethical incidents that prompted their punishment than helping disclosure. Together, these processes suggest that the disclosure penalty on moral reputation will be smaller for third-party punishment than for helping—and may even reverse in some circumstances. We test these predictions across five preregistered experiments (total $N = 3{,}979$). By identifying when and why disclosure harms rather than helps moral reputation, the present research advances a broader understanding of the reputational consequences of disclosing prosocial behavior.

Prosocial Behavior and Moral Reputation

Social psychology research has suggested that prosociality may occur both through behaviors that directly benefit others (e.g., helping) and through those that uphold norms (e.g., third-party punishment; Dhaliwal et al., 2021; Jordan & Rand, 2020; Van de Vyver & Abrams, 2015; cf. Eisenberg et al., 2015). Helpers incur costs to increase the welfare of others (e.g., by making charitable donations), while third-party punishers incur costs to punish unethical perpetrators (Fehr & Fischbacher, 2004).

Whereas research on prosocial behavior has traditionally centered on helping and other forms of direct assistance (e.g., Batson & Powell, 2003; Eisenberg et al., 2015), scholars have increasingly examined the role of third-party punishment in providing indirect benefits to others (e.g., Jordan et al., 2016). Third-party punishment is a common response to unethical behavior. In one survey, adults who were not themselves victims reported punishing norm-violators 35% of the time (Molho et al., 2020), while lab studies show that around 50% of participants routinely pay to punish those who behave selfishly toward others in economic games (e.g., Fehr & Fischbacher, 2004).

Individuals earn moral reputations, in part, through engaging in prosocial behavior. When others observe or hear about their prosocial acts—be it helping or third-party punishment—they draw positive inferences about the actor. Nonetheless, evaluations of punishers and helpers differ in critical ways. Whereas helping tends to signal a uniformly positive set of traits, third-party punishment signals a more mixed profile. For example, both helpers and third-party punishers are seen as trustworthy, cooperative, and moral (Dhaliwal et al., 2021; Jordan et al., 2016; Raihani & Bshary, 2015b). However, third-party punishers are also perceived as dominant and aggressive (Gordon et al., 2014; Raihani & Bshary, 2015a; Seubert & Böckler, 2025), which may elicit fear and dislike (Brady & Sivanathan, 2024; Gaertig et al., 2019; Raihani & Bshary, 2015a). These trait inferences contribute to overall judgments of their moral character.

Moral character judgments depend not only on whether individuals engage in prosocial behavior, but also on their assumed motives (Carlson et al., 2022; Carlson & Zaki, 2018). For example, observers consider whether prosocial behavior takes place in private or public, which may raise suspicion that the prosocial actor was motivated by a desire to look good in front of others (Engeler & Raihani, 2024; Inesi & Rios, 2023; Jordan & Kteily, 2023; Siem & Stürmer, 2019). Similarly, when someone personally benefits from their prosocial act, observers consider whether this individual may have been motivated by a desire to obtain these personal benefits rather than by altruism (Barasch et al., 2014; Carlson & Zaki, 2018). Another important cue for perceived moral character is whether actors choose to disclose, or not disclose, their own prosocial behavior to others (Berman et al., 2015; Berman & Silver, 2022; De Freitas et al., 2019; Silver & Small, 2024). By disclosure, we mean intentionally communicating this information to others—in this case, information about their own prosocial acts. In the following sections, we theorize about how disclosure decisions lead to different motive attributions, depending on the type of prosocial behavior.

Disclosure and the Motive to Self-Promote

Prior research suggests that observers may become suspicious about a prosocial actor's motives when they choose to disclose their helping acts. Because helping signals uniformly desirable traits, disclosing helping is often interpreted as an attempt to obtain the reputational benefits associated with being seen as moral. As a result, observers judge helpers who disclose their helping acts less favorably than helpers who remain silent (Berman et al., 2015; Carlson et al., 2022). Consistent with this account, remaining anonymous earns helpers stronger moral reputations when their actions are subsequently discovered (Berman et al., 2015; De Freitas et al., 2019).

We predict that this disclosure penalty is weaker for third-party punishment than for helping. Unlike helping, third-party punishment does not send uniformly positive signals about traits. Third-party punishers may be seen as principled, courageous, and willing to enforce norms

(Barclay, 2006; Fehr & Fischbacher, 2004; Nelissen, 2008), but they are also seen as aggressive, judgmental, and threatening, which inspires fear in others (Gordon et al., 2014; Raihani & Bshary, 2015a; Seubert & Böckler, 2025). Because the traits associated with third-party punishment are more mixed, disclosing such behavior should be less clearly attributable to a desire to claim moral credit. That is, although disclosure may still be interpreted by observers as an act of self-promotion, this inference should be weaker when the disclosed act is third-party punishment rather than helping.

The same logic also changes how observers interpret silence about these acts. In the context of helping, remaining silent is likely to appear especially modest because the actor forgoes credit for an unambiguously positive act. In the context of third-party punishment, however, finding out that someone chose to remain silent may not be rewarded in the same way. Because third-party punishment is associated with mixed traits, withholding information about such behavior may be interpreted not only as modesty, but also as an attempt to avoid signaling those mixed traits.

Taken together, we predict that disclosure decisions will produce smaller differences in perceived self-promotion motives for third-party punishment than for helping. For helping, disclosure should heighten self-promotion attributions and nondisclosure should reduce them. For third-party punishment, by contrast, disclosure should appear to be a less obvious attempt to claim moral credit, while nondisclosure should be a less clear signal of modesty. These attributional patterns should, in turn, shape actors' moral reputations differently.

Disclosure and the Motive to Inform Others

Disclosing prosocial behavior does not just provide signals about an actor's moral character: it also conveys information about the circumstances surrounding the act. An important feature of third-party punishment is that it takes place upon a perpetrator behaving unethically. Information about unethical behavior may be valuable to others, because it can alert them to community-relevant threats and facilitate cooperative responses (Feinberg et al., 2014; Morrison, 2011). By threats, we refer to unethical behaviors that expose other members of a social group to harm, exploitation, or victimization.

In contrast, helping can occur when no unethical behavior has taken place. For example, someone can help by donating money to victims of a natural disaster or by driving a neighbor to the hospital after an accident. In the absence of threat, it becomes less important for others to find out about these helping acts. On average, a prosocial actor's disclosure decisions are therefore more consequential for community members in the context of third-party punishment compared to helping—because these disclosures tend to convey more information about relevant threats.

Prior research has shown that observers judge actors less harshly for disclosure when they have good reasons to disclose their own prosocial behavior. For instance, when actors subtly disclose their own prosocial behavior to close acquaintances, they face less reputational backlash (Bird et al., 2018; Hoffman et al., 2018). Similarly, expressing a desire to recruit others to donate to a good cause attenuates the backlash actors face from sharing their past donations (Berman et al., 2015). Because disclosure about third-party punishment conveys information about threats, observers are likely to infer that actors who disclose are motivated to inform others. This likely has positive consequences for moral reputation.

Taken together, we predict that disclosure will be more strongly associated with a motive to inform others for third-party punishment than for helping. Furthermore, these attributions should positively shape judgments of actors' moral character. Indeed, when the perceived motive to inform others is sufficiently strong, third-party punishment disclosure may lead to more favorable moral character judgments than remaining silent about these acts.

This logic suggests two clear boundary conditions. First, if a third-party punisher is interacting with others for whom the preceding unethical behavior is not threatening (e.g., because they live in another country and the threat is therefore less relevant to them), then disclosure decisions will be more weakly associated with a perceived motive to inform others—attenuating the positive downstream consequences for moral reputation. Second, we have assumed that the circumstances surrounding third-party punishment are more threatening to communities than those surrounding helping. However, if an actor helps by responding to an unethical act (e.g., by helping the victim), then disclosure decisions about helping will be more strongly associated with a perceived motive to inform others.

Overview of Studies

Across five preregistered experimental studies (total N = 3,979 participants), we examine the effect of disclosing one's own prosocial behavior—third-party punishment and helping—on moral reputation.

We focus on occasions when punishers directly confront perpetrators of unethical acts (Czopp & Monteith, 2003). Confronting perpetrators reduces the likelihood that perpetrators reoffend by signaling the confronter's disapproval and eliciting feelings of guilt (Chaney & Sanchez, 2018; Czopp et al., 2006; Parker et al., 2018; Sarin et al., 2021). At the same time, confrontation is costly for punishers because these actors assume retaliation risk (Ashburn-Nardo et al., 2014; Czopp & Monteith, 2003; Gordon & Lea, 2016; Kennedy & Schweitzer, 2018; Monin et al., 2008) and incur emotional costs, including distress and anxiety (Adams & Mullen, 2012; Kish-Gephart et al., 2009).

In a pilot study, we validated two assumptions that underpin our theory: (1) observers expect that actors anticipate receiving more mixed reactions for third-party punishment than for helping, and (2) on average, third-party punishment incidents present greater community-relevant threats than helping incidents. In Studies 1–2, we generated ten vignettes—five third-party punishment scenarios and five helping scenarios, using ChatGPT-4o (OpenAI, 2024) to ensure that scenarios were realistic and diverse (Simonsohn et al., 2025)—and randomly presented these to participants, along with information about disclosure strategies. In Study 1, we investigated the perceived motives of disclosing (versus not disclosing)—self-promotion and informing others—across these prosocial behaviors. In Study 2, we examined our central claim—that the reputational penalty of disclosure is smaller for third-party punishment than for helping. In Study 3, to provide clarity on the effects we identified in Studies 1–2, we measured perceived motives together with perceived moral character to conduct an initial test of mediation. We also contrasted disclosure strategies for each prosocial behavior to a control condition. In Study 4, we examined the perceived motive to inform others in more depth by manipulating the relevance of threat to the audience—and its downstream effect on moral reputation. Finally, in Study 5, we provide a comprehensive test of our proposed theoretical model using a single scenario and manipulating the prosocial behavior exhibited, the disclosure strategy, and the relevance of the threat to the audience.

Transparency and Openness

We preregistered all of our main studies (Study 1: https://aspredicted.org/k8dg8h.pdf; Study 2: https://aspredicted.org/p3ha2a.pdf; Study 3: https://aspredicted.org/ig633q.pdf; Study 4: https://aspredicted.org/ur5e36.pdf; Study 5: https://aspredicted.org/nb3bb7.pdf). Our pilot study was not preregistered. Our studies were approved by the Institutional Review Board of the authors' institution (Approval No. REC837). All participants provided informed consent prior to participation. Deviations from our preregistered plans are reported in *Supplementary Table S1* (following guidelines in Willroth & Atherton, 2024). We report how we determined sample sizes, data exclusions, manipulations, and measures, and we follow Journal Article Reporting Standards throughout (Kazak, 2018). Study materials, anonymized data, and analysis code are available on the Open Science Framework (https://osf.io/ph2k9/overview?view_only=eb2b7200b8ed4991ae2d872c59de8faa); supplementary analyses are reported in the *Supplementary Online Materials*. We analyzed data using R Version 4.5.1 (R Core Team, 2025) and several open-source packages (see *Supplementary Online Materials*). We used ChatGPT-4o (OpenAI, 2024) to develop the prosocial behavior scenarios used in Studies 1–3 and to conduct basic literature reviews; we used ChatGPT-5.5 (OpenAI, 2026) to improve code for data analysis and revise selected sentences in this manuscript.

Pilot Study

We conducted a pilot study to evaluate two assumptions underlying our theorizing (see *Supplementary Online Materials* for full details). First, we tested whether prosocial actors are presumed to anticipate receiving more mixed reactions from observers for third-party punishment than for helping. If so, this would support our prediction that disclosing third-party punishment is less clearly attributable to self-promotion than disclosing helping is. Second, we tested whether the situational contexts giving rise to third-party punishment are perceived as more threatening than those giving rise to helping. If so, this would support our prediction that disclosing third-party punishment is more clearly attributable to a motive to inform others.

Drawing on the critical incident technique (Flanagan, 1954), 251 adults from the United Kingdom provided stories about either helping or third-party punishment on Prolific. We then recruited two research assistants, blind to our hypotheses, to code how the prosocial actor in the stories would anticipate others reacting if they found out about the behavior. This included anticipated positive reactions (four items, e.g., "story-teller would think others would develop a positive impression of them"; Zhang et al., 2020; ICC(C,1) = 0.58), and anticipated negative reactions (four items, e.g., "story-teller would worry about what others might think about them"; Carleton et al., 2006; ICC(C,1) = 0.61). Coders also rated stories for threat (if you lived in this community, to what extent would this event make you feel "nervous", "anxious", "worried", and "apprehensive"; Kouchaki & Desai, 2015; ICC(C,1) = 0.72), and safety (if you lived in this community, to what extent would this event make you feel "safe", "secure", "content", and "warm"; Gilbert et al., 2008; ICC(C,1) = 0.47).

Linear mixed-effects regression models showed that coders believed that prosocial actors anticipated similarly positive reactions to third-party punishment and helping (b = -0.09, SE = 0.13, $t(249)$ = -0.67, p = .506; M_{TPP} = 3.65, SD_{TPP} = 1.02 versus M_{Help} = 3.74, SD_{Help} = 0.99). However, relative to helpers, coders believed that third-party punishers would anticipate more negative reactions (b = 0.73, SE = 0.06, $t(249)$ = 12.82, p < .001; M_{TPP} = 1.84, SD_{TPP} = 0.55 versus M_{Help} = 1.12, SD_{Help} = 0.33). Finally, coders rated that people in the community would experience more threat in the case of third-party punishment versus helping (b = 1.68, SE = 0.15, $t(249)$ = 11.18, p < .001; M_{TPP} = 3.38, SD_{TPP} = 1.45 versus M_{Help} = 1.70, SD_{Help} = 0.88), and less community safety (b = -1.14, SE = 0.05, $t(249)$ = -21.02, p < .001; M_{TPP} = 1.18, SD_{TPP} = 0.31 versus M_{Help} = 2.31, SD_{Help} = 0.52).

Thus, across a wide variety of real events, third-party punishers were presumed to anticipate more mixed reactions than helpers, and third-party punishment incidents were associated with greater community-relevant threat and lower safety than helping acts. Together, these assumptions provide initial empirical support for the two motive-attribution pathways that we predict give rise to the different moral reputation consequences of disclosing helping and third-party punishment.

Study 1

In Study 1, we examine whether the choice to disclose (versus not disclose) prosocial behavior leads to different motive attributions when it involves helping versus third-party punishment. Specifically, we test the prediction that disclosing one's third-party punishments is less diagnostic of an attempt to self-promote and more diagnostic of an attempt to inform others—relative to disclosing one's helping acts. We use the *stimulus sampling procedure* outlined by Simonsohn and colleagues (2025) to develop ten realistic helping and third-party punishment vignette scenarios using ChatGPT-4o (OpenAI, 2024).

Method

Participants

We designed our study to be sufficiently powered to detect a small-to-medium interaction of Cohen's $f = 0.15$ and determined using G*Power (Faul et al., 2009) that a sample of 351 participants would be appropriate (80% power at $\alpha = 0.05$). To be conservative and account for exclusions, we recruited 382 adults from the United Kingdom on Prolific for £0.45 in compensation. As preregistered, we excluded 21 participants who failed an attention check (and were directed out of the study before seeing materials). We also excluded one participant for providing incomplete study measures (retaining their incomplete data did not affect the results).

After exclusions, the final dataset includes 360 participants (56.9% women; 41.4% men; 1.1% preferred not to say; 0.6% did not disclose; M_{Age} = 39.54; SD_{Age} = 13.45).

Procedure

We prompted ChatGPT-4o (OpenAI, 2024) to generate ten vignette scenarios: five involving helping (e.g., the actor spends their afternoon picking up litter in a park) and five involving third-party punishment by confronting a stranger (e.g., the actor confronts a stranger they see kicking over a neighbor's garden gnome). This approach allowed us to gather a diverse set of prosocial behaviors (see *Appendix* for full vignette texts and *Supplementary Online Materials* for prompts). We then randomly assigned participants to read one of the ten vignettes. Participants were also randomly assigned to read that the actor either posted about the incident on social media (*Disclose* condition) or posted about their weekend plans (*Not Disclose* condition; see Berman et al., 2015). The weekend plans were drawn at random from a list of ten activities (e.g., going to the cinema) and were not theoretically relevant; accordingly, we collapsed our analysis across activities. Thus, Study 1 uses a 2 (Prosocial Behavior: *TPP* versus *Help*) × 2 (Disclosure Strategy: *Disclose* versus *Not Disclose*) between-subjects design, with vignettes nested within prosocial behavior type.

Participants then assessed the actor's perceived motive to self-promote (five items, e.g., "Alex likes to show off if he gets the chance"; Berman et al., 2015; 7-point scales; 1 = *strongly disagree*, 7 = *strongly agree*; α = 0.95) and perceived motive to inform others (five items, e.g., "Lisa was taking the initiative to provide information that her Facebook followers would find useful."; 7-point scales; 1 = *strongly disagree*, 7 = s*trongly agree*; α = 0.71). Participants also completed a prosocial behavior manipulation check (7-point scale; 1 = *actor imposed a punishment on target*; 4 = *actor neither punished nor helped target*; 7 = *actor provided help to* *target*) and a disclosure strategy manipulation check ("actor told people about what he/she did earlier in the day"; 5-point scale; 1 = *strongly disagree;* 5 = *strongly agree)*.

Results

For this and all subsequent studies, we report the focal tests and corresponding planned contrasts in the main text; full statistical results for all dependent variables are reported in the *Supplementary Online Materials*.

Mixed-effects models were estimated using the lmerTest package in R, which employs Satterthwaite-approximated t tests and degrees of freedom (Kuznetsova et al., 2017). Categorical predictors were effect-coded, and planned contrasts were estimated from the fitted mixed-effects models using the emmeans package in R (Lenth et al., 2019).

Manipulation Checks

Prosocial Behavior Manipulation Check. A linear mixed-effects regression model predicting the prosocial behavior manipulation check (with random intercepts for vignette and fixed effects for Prosocial Behavior and Disclosure Strategy, and their interaction) revealed the intended effect of Prosocial Behavior (b = 3.31, SE = 0.11, $t(356)$ = 31.18, p < .001), such that participants perceived the actor to have helped more in the *Help* condition compared to the *TPP* condition (M_{Help} = 6.64, SD_{Help} = 0.84 versus M_{TPP} = 3.33, SD_{TPP} = 1.15).

Disclosure Strategy Manipulation Check. A linear mixed-effects regression model predicting the disclosure strategy manipulation check (with random intercepts for vignette and fixed effects for Prosocial Behavior and Disclosure Strategy, and their interaction) revealed the intended effect of Disclosure Strategy (b = 2.91, SE = 0.10, $t(356)$ = 28.23, p < .001), such that participants perceived the actor to have disclosed more about their earlier actions in the *Disclose* condition compared to the *Not Disclose* condition ($M_{Disclose} = 4.51$, $SD_{Disclose} = 0.92$ versus $M_{NotDisclose} = 1.60$, $SD_{NotDisclose} = 1.03$).

Perceived Motive to Self-Promote

A linear mixed-effects regression model predicting perceived motive to self-promote (with random intercepts for vignette and fixed effects for Prosocial Behavior, Disclosure Strategy, and their interaction) showed a significant Prosocial Behavior × Disclosure Strategy interaction ($b = 0.72$, $SE = 0.26$, $t(348) = 2.79$, $p = .006$). Planned contrasts revealed that within the *Help* condition, perceived motive to self-promote was higher when the prosocial actor disclosed compared to when they did not, $t(348) = 10.21$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 1.52$ ($M_{Disclose} = 5.74$, $SD_{Disclose} = 1.14$ versus $M_{NotDisclose} = 3.89$, $SD_{NotDisclose} = 1.32$). As predicted, this effect was weaker in the *TPP* condition, $t(348) = 6.27$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 0.93$ ($M_{Disclose} = 5.15$, $SD_{Disclose} = 1.09$ versus $M_{NotDisclose} = 4.00$, $SD_{NotDisclose} = 1.33$).

Perceived Motive to Inform Others

A linear mixed-effects regression model predicting perceived motive to inform others (with random intercepts for vignette and fixed effects for Prosocial Behavior, Disclosure Strategy, and their interaction) showed a significant Prosocial Behavior × Disclosure Strategy interaction ($b = -0.89$, $SE = 0.22$, $t(348) = -4.10$, $p < .001$). Planned contrasts revealed that in the *Help* condition, perceived motive to inform others was higher when the prosocial actor disclosed compared to when they did not, $t(348) = 2.19$, $p = .029$, Cohen's $d = 0.33$ ($M_{Disclose} = 3.67$, $SD_{Disclose} = 1.04$ versus $M_{NotDisclose} = 3.33$, $SD_{NotDisclose} = 0.83$). As predicted, this effect was stronger in the *TPP* condition, $t(348) = 7.99$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 1.19$ ($M_{Disclose} = 4.16$, $SD_{Disclose} = 1.30$ versus $M_{NotDisclose} = 2.94$, $SD_{NotDisclose} = 0.88$).

Discussion

Study 1 shows that disclosure choices are more diagnostic of the perceived motive to self-promote when the prosocial behavior involves helping rather than third-party punishment. At the same time, disclosure choices are more diagnostic of the perceived motive to inform others when the prosocial behavior involves third-party punishment rather than helping.

Study 2

In Study 2, we examine our core hypothesis—that the reputational penalty of disclosure is smaller for third-party punishment than for helping. We do so by leveraging the same vignettes from Study 1 but assessing evaluations of actors' moral character.

Method

Participants

We designed our study to be sufficiently powered to detect a small interaction of Cohen's $f = 0.10$ and determined using G*Power (Faul et al., 2009) that a sample of 787 participants would be appropriate (80% power at $\alpha = 0.05$). To be conservative and account for exclusions, we recruited 830 adults from the United Kingdom on Prolific for £0.25 in compensation. As preregistered, we excluded 27 participants who failed an attention check (and were directed out of the study before seeing materials). We also excluded 13 participants for providing incomplete study measures (retaining their incomplete data did not affect the results). After exclusions, the final dataset includes 790 participants (53.0% women; 46.1% men; 0.1% preferred not to say; 0.8% did not disclose; $M_{Age} = 46.42$; $SD_{Age} = 14.35$).

Procedure

We used the same procedure as Study 1, resulting in the same 2 (Prosocial Behavior: *TPP* versus *Help*) × 2 (Disclosure Strategy: *Disclose* versus *Not Disclose*) between-subjects design, with vignettes once again nested within prosocial behavior type (i.e., five helping vignettes and five third-party punishment vignettes). The only difference from Study 1 was the dependent measure, which in this case was perceived moral character.

Participants rated the actor's moral character using eight items (courageous, fair, principled, responsible, trustworthy, just, honest, and loyal; Goodwin et al., 2014; 9-point scales; 1 = *not at all*, 9 = *extremely*; $\alpha = 0.94$). We selected these traits because they score higher on morality but lower on warmth, since our goal was to focus specifically on moral character evaluations. Finally, participants completed a prosocial behavior manipulation check and a disclosure strategy manipulation check using the same items as Study 1.

Results

Manipulation Checks

Prosocial Behavior Manipulation Check. A linear mixed-effects regression model predicting the prosocial behavior manipulation check (with random intercepts for vignette and fixed effects for Prosocial Behavior and Disclosure Strategy, and their interaction) revealed a significant effect of Prosocial Behavior ($b = 3.29$, $SE = 0.14$, $t(8) = 24.30$, $p < .001$). Consistent with our desired manipulation, participants perceived the actor to have helped more in the *Help* condition compared to the *TPP* condition ($M_{Help} = 6.76$, $SD_{Help} = 0.81$ versus $M_{TPP} = 3.47$, $SD_{TPP} = 1.03$).

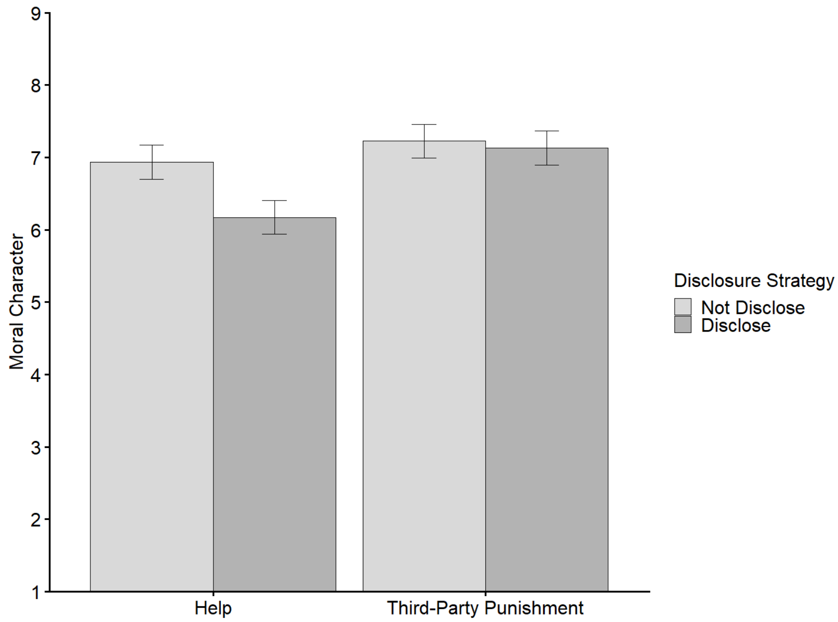
Disclosure Strategy Manipulation Check. A linear mixed-effects regression model predicting the disclosure strategy manipulation check (with random intercepts for vignette and fixed effects for Prosocial Behavior and Disclosure Strategy, and their interaction) revealed a significant effect of Disclosure Strategy ($b = 3.26$, $SE = 0.06$, $t(786) = 55.77$, $p < .001$). Consistent with our desired manipulation, participants perceived the actor to have disclosed more about their earlier actions in the *Disclose* condition compared to the *Not Disclose* condition ($M_{Disclose}$ = 4.67, $SD_{Disclose}$ = 0.79 versus $M_{NotDisclose}$ = 1.41, $SD_{NotDisclose}$ = 0.85).

Moral Character

Per our preregistration plan, we ran a linear mixed-effects regression model predicting moral character with Prosocial Behavior, Disclosure Strategy, and their interaction as fixed effects and random intercepts for vignette. The Prosocial Behavior × Disclosure Strategy interaction was significant, b = -0.67, SE = 0.18, $t(778)$ = -3.66, p < .001 (see *Figure 1*; also see *Supplementary Online Materials* for analyses by scenario). Planned contrasts revealed that in the *Help* condition, perceived moral character was lower when the prosocial actor disclosed compared to when they did not, $t(778)$ = -5.88, p < .001, Cohen's d = -0.59 ($M_{Disclose}$ = 6.17, $SD_{Disclose}$ = 1.54 versus $M_{NotDisclose}$ = 6.94, $SD_{NotDisclose}$ = 1.15). However, moral character ratings did not differ as a function of disclosure strategy in the *TPP* condition, $t(778)$ = -0.72, p = .470, Cohen's d = -0.07 ($M_{Disclose}$ = 7.13, $SD_{Disclose}$ = 1.27 versus $M_{NotDisclose}$ = 7.23, $SD_{NotDisclose}$ = 1.18).

Figure 1

The Effect of Disclosure Strategy by Prosocial Behavior on Moral Character (Study 2)



Note. Error bars represent 95% confidence intervals.

Discussion

Study 2 supports our central claim that third-party punishment disclosure elicits a smaller penalty on moral reputation than helping disclosure.

Study 3

Study 3 builds on our previous findings in two ways. First, we directly test the proposed mediation process by assessing motive attributions and moral character evaluations within a single study. Specifically, we examine whether disclosure choices affect moral character evaluations differently for helping versus third-party punishment via motive attributions of self-promotion and informing others. Second, we include a control condition in which participants receive no information about the actor's disclosure strategy. In this condition, participants read about the prosocial behavior—either helping or third-party punishment—and then evaluate the actor's moral character without learning whether they disclosed their prosocial behavior. By comparing results from each disclosure strategy condition to a control condition, we aim to isolate the unique effect (positive, negative, or null) of actors choosing to disclose and choosing not to disclose their own helping or third-party punishment.

Method

Participants

We designed our study to be sufficiently powered to detect a small interaction of Cohen's $f = 0.10$ and determined using G*Power (Faul et al., 2009) that a sample of 967 participants would be appropriate (80% power at $\alpha = 0.05$). To be conservative and account for exclusions, we recruited 1,036 adults from the United Kingdom on Prolific to participate in our study for £0.40 in compensation. As preregistered, we excluded 28 participants who failed an attention check (and were directed out of the study before seeing materials). We also excluded 17 participants for providing incomplete study measures (retaining their incomplete data did not affect the results). After these exclusions, the final dataset includes 991 participants (56.8% women; 42.6% men; 0.3% preferred not to say; 0.3% did not disclose; $M_{Age} = 44.52$; $SD_{Age} =$ 13.23). We employed a 2 (Prosocial Behavior: *TPP* versus *Help*) × 3 (Disclosure Strategy: *Disclose* versus *Not Disclose* versus *Control*) between-subjects design.

Procedure

We first examined the effect sizes of disclosure strategy condition on moral character evaluations in the vignettes used in Study 2. For each type of prosocial behavior, we selected the vignette in which the effect of disclosure strategy on perceived moral character was closest to the average effect (within that behavior type). This procedure resulted in the selection of the "umbrella" helping vignette ("During a storm, Alex notices his neighbour's umbrella has broken. He hands over his spare umbrella, ensuring the neighbour can stay dry") and the "stray dog" third-party punishment vignette ("Lisa sees a teenager hitting a stray dog with a stick. She intervenes, reprimanding him for mistreating animals and urging him to stop"; see *Supplementary Online Materials* for more details regarding the selection process). Participants were randomly assigned to read the selected *Help* or *TPP* scenario.

Next, we manipulated the actor's disclosure strategy using the same procedure as in Studies 1–2. We additionally included a *Control* condition, where participants did not read any information regarding whether the actor disclosed their prosocial behavior.

Participants first provided moral character evaluations using the same scale as Study 2 ($\alpha = 0.95$). Next, participants in the *Disclose* and the *Not Disclose* conditions provided measures of perceived motive to self-promote ($\alpha = 0.97$) and perceived motive to inform others ($\alpha = 0.71$) using the same scales as Study 1. Participants in the *Control* condition did not complete these measures because there was no disclosure strategy. Finally, participants in all conditions completed a prosocial behavior manipulation check and a disclosure strategy manipulation check using the same items as Studies 1–2.

Results

Manipulation Checks

Prosocial Behavior Manipulation Check. A two-way Prosocial Behavior × Disclosure Strategy ANOVA on the prosocial behavior manipulation check revealed a significant main effect of Prosocial Behavior, $F(1, 985) = 2{,}961.85$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $f = 1.73$. Consistent with our intended manipulation, participants perceived the actor to have helped more in the *Help* condition compared to the *TPP* condition ($M_{Help} = 6.77$, $SD_{Help} = 0.78$ versus $M_{TPP} = 3.17$, $SD_{TPP} = 1.25$).

Disclosure Strategy Manipulation Check. A two-way Prosocial Behavior × Disclosure Strategy ANOVA on the disclosure strategy manipulation check revealed a significant main effect of Disclosure Strategy, $F(2, 985) = 1{,}495.05$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $f = 1.74$. As intended, participants perceived the actor to have disclosed their earlier actions more in the *Disclose* condition ($M_{Disclose} = 4.73$, $SD_{Disclose} = 0.64$) compared to either the *Control* condition ($M_{Control} = 2.25$, $SD_{Control} = 1.23$), $t(985) = 37.34$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 2.90$, or the *Not Disclose* condition ($M_{NotDisclose} = 1.20$, $SD_{NotDisclose} = 0.62$), $t(985) = 53.22$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 4.14$. Participants also perceived the actor to have disclosed less about their earlier actions in the *Not Disclose* condition compared to the *Control* condition, $t(985) = -15.84$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $d = -1.24$.

Moral Character

A two-way Prosocial Behavior × Disclosure Strategy ANOVA predicting moral character revealed a significant interaction, $F(2, 985) = 15.61$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $f = 0.18$ (see *Figure 2*).

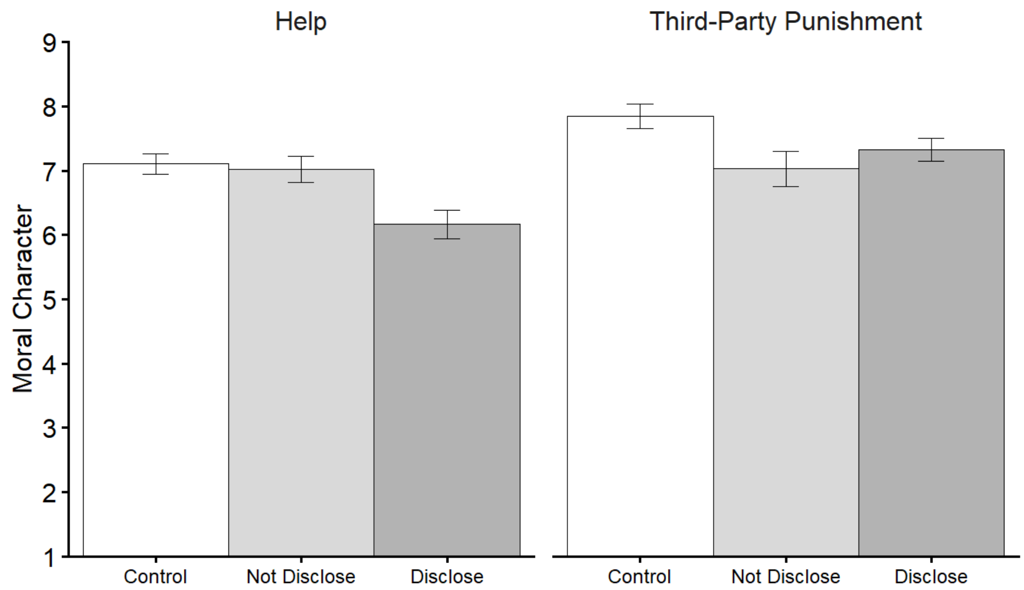
We first compared the *Not Disclose* condition to the *Control* condition to examine how choosing *not* to disclose affects moral character ratings. For helpers, nondisclosure led to similar moral character ascriptions compared to those in the *Control* condition, $t(985) = -0.56$, $p = .839$, Cohen's $d = -0.06$ ($M_{NotDisclose} = 7.02$, $SD_{NotDisclose} = 1.31$ versus $M_{Control} = 7.11$, $SD_{Control} = 1.03$). For punishers, nondisclosure led to lower moral character perceptions than the *Control* condition, $t(985) = -5.52$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $d = -0.61$ ($M_{NotDisclose} = 7.03$, $SD_{NotDisclose} = 1.80$ versus $M_{Control} = 7.85$, $SD_{Control} = 1.23$). Thus, withholding information about third-party punishment was worse than withholding information about helping—a possibility supported by a non-preregistered 2 (Prosocial Behavior: *Help* versus *TPP*) × 2 (Disclosure Strategy: *Not Disclose* versus *Control*) interaction contrast, $F(1, 985) = 12.20$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $f = 0.11$.

We then compared the *Disclose* condition to the *Control* condition to examine how choosing to disclose affects moral character ratings. For helpers, disclosing led to lower perceived moral character compared to the *Control* condition, $t(985) = -6.35$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $d = -0.70$ ($M_{Disclose} = 6.17$, $SD_{Disclose} = 1.42$ versus $M_{Control} = 7.11$, $SD_{Control} = 1.03$). For punishers, a similar pattern emerged, $t(985) = -3.51$, $p = .001$, Cohen's $d = -0.39$ ($M_{Disclose} = 7.33$, $SD_{Disclose} = 1.15$ versus $M_{Control} = 7.85$, $SD_{Control} = 1.23$), although this effect was smaller. Thus, disclosing information about helping was worse than disclosing information about third-party punishment, a possibility supported by a non-preregistered 2 (Prosocial Behavior: *Help* versus *TPP*) × 2 (Disclosure Strategy: *Disclose* versus *Control*) interaction contrast, $F(1, 985) = 4.07$, $p = .044$, Cohen's $f = 0.06$.

Finally, we conducted a non-preregistered 2 (Prosocial Behavior: *Help* versus *TPP*) × 2 (Disclosure Strategy: *Disclose* versus *Not Disclose*) interaction contrast to investigate whether we replicated the effect that emerged in Study 2. This revealed a significant interaction, replicating Study 2's results, $F(1, 985) = 30.50$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $f = 0.18$. Consistent with Study 2, disclosing led to lower ascriptions of moral character than not disclosing for helping, $t(985) = -5.77$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $d = -0.64$ ($M_{Disclose} = 6.17$, $SD_{Disclose} = 1.42$ versus $M_{NotDisclose} = 7.02$, $SD_{NotDisclose} = 1.31$). In contrast, when the actor engaged in *TPP*, there was no significant difference in moral character ratings between disclosing and not disclosing, $t(985) = 2.03$, $p = .106$, Cohen's $d = 0.22$ ($M_{Disclose} = 7.33$, $SD_{Disclose} = 1.15$ versus $M_{NotDisclose} = 7.03$, $SD_{NotDisclose} = 1.80$).

Figure 2

The Effect of Disclosure Strategy by Prosocial Behavior on Moral Character (Study 3)



Note. Error bars represent 95% confidence intervals.

Perceived Motive to Self-Promote

A two-way Prosocial Behavior × Disclosure Strategy ANOVA predicting perceived motive to self-promote revealed a significant interaction, $F(1, 658) = 27.33$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $f = 0.20$. Planned contrasts showed that, in the *Help* condition, disclosing led to stronger perceptions of self-promotion motives relative to not disclosing, $t(658) = 22.64$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 2.50$ ($M_{Disclose} = 5.87$, $SD_{Disclose} = 1.09$ versus $M_{NotDisclose} = 2.91$, $SD_{NotDisclose} = 1.20$). Disclosing also increased perceived self-promotion in the *TPP* condition, but, consistent with our hypothesis, this effect was weaker, $t(658) = 15.42$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 1.69$ ($M_{Disclose} = 4.84$, $SD_{Disclose} = 1.24$ versus $M_{NotDisclose} = 2.85$, $SD_{NotDisclose} = 1.20$).

Perceived Motive to Inform Others

A two-way Prosocial Behavior × Disclosure Strategy ANOVA predicting perceived motive to inform others revealed a significant interaction, $F(1, 658) = 78.06$, $p < .001$, Cohen's f

= 0.34. Planned contrasts showed that in the *Help* condition, disclosing did not produce a significant increase in the perceived motive to inform others relative to not disclosing, $t(658) = 1.92$, $p = .056$, Cohen's $d = 0.21$ ($M_{Disclose} = 3.49$, $SD_{Disclose} = 0.91$ versus $M_{NotDisclose} = 3.29$, $SD_{NotDisclose} = 0.87$). In contrast, in the *TPP* condition, disclosing led to a significantly higher perceived motive to inform others than not disclosing, $t(658) = 14.49$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 1.59$ ($M_{Disclose} = 4.36$, $SD_{Disclose} = 1.11$ versus $M_{NotDisclose} = 2.86$, $SD_{NotDisclose} = 0.87$).

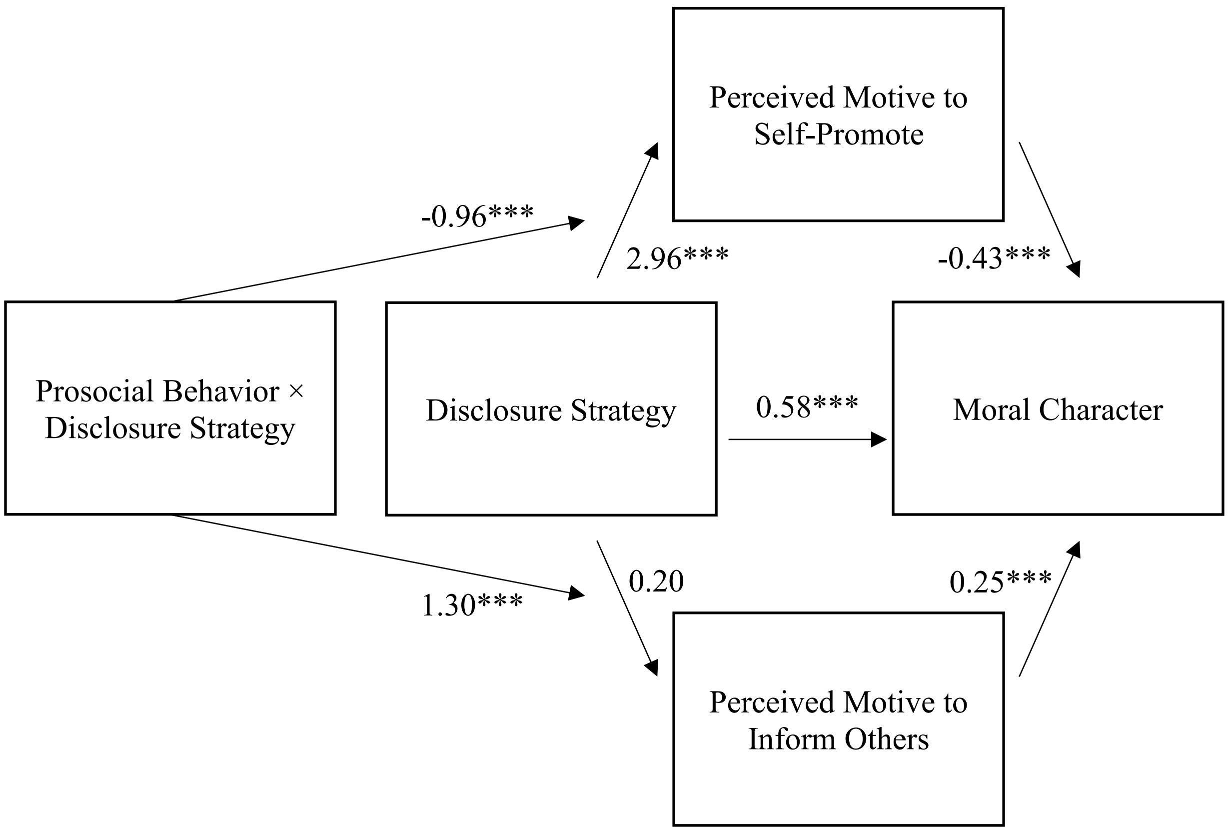
Indirect Effects

Finally, we examined whether the effect of Disclosure Strategy on moral character was independently mediated by perceived motives to self-promote and inform others, and whether these indirect pathways were moderated by Prosocial Behavior, using Hayes' PROCESS Macro Model 7 (Hayes, 2017; see *Figure 3*). Because perceived motives were not measured in the *Control* condition, indirect-effect analyses included only participants in the *Disclose* and *Not Disclose* conditions. Using 20,000 bootstrapped samples, we identified significant indices of moderated mediation (perceived motive to self-promote path: $b = 0.42$, $SE = 0.10$, 95% CI [0.24, 0.62]; perceived motive to inform others path: $b = 0.33$, $SE = 0.10$, 95% CI [0.14, 0.54]). These moderated mediation results indicated that the indirect effects of Disclosure Strategy on moral character judgments via perceived motive to self-promote and perceived motive to inform others were different depending on Prosocial Behavior condition. Disclosing had a stronger negative indirect effect on perceived moral character via perceived motive to self-promote in the *Help* condition ($b = -1.28$, $SE = 0.15$, 95% CI [-1.59, -0.99]) compared to the *TPP* condition ($b = -0.86$, $SE = 0.11$, 95% CI [-1.08, -0.66]). Further, disclosing had a stronger positive indirect effect on perceived moral character via perceived motive to inform others in the *TPP* condition ($b = 0.38$, $SE = 0.11$, 95% CI [0.17, 0.60]), compared to the *Help* condition ($b = 0.05$, $SE = 0.03$, 95%

CI [0.00, 0.11]). For a discussion and analysis of possible alternative causal models, see *Supplementary Online Materials*.

Figure 3

Moderated Mediation Results (Hayes PROCESS Model 7; Study 3)



Note. Values represent unstandardized beta coefficients.
*** $p < .001$.

Discussion

Study 3 replicated core patterns from Studies 1–2 using a single design. Disclosure choices lead to larger differences in the perceived motive to self-promote when the actor had helped, but larger differences in the perceived motive to inform others when the actor had engaged in third-party punishment. These independent pathways were strongly associated with the perceived moral character of the actor. Overall, disclosing (versus not disclosing) prosocial behavior was less damaging to moral reputation in the case of third-party punishment compared to helping.

The addition of a control condition provides clarity on how disclosure affects perceptions of moral character. Relative to their respective control conditions, helping disclosure exerted greater damage on moral reputation than third-party punishment disclosure. Further, nondisclosure of third-party punishment was worse for the actor's moral reputation than nondisclosure of helping. Interestingly, for third-party punishment, both disclosing and not disclosing were evaluated less positively than the control condition. This pattern suggests a possible double bind—disclosure of third-party punishment prompts perceptions of self-promotion, while nondisclosure prompts concern that the actor has withheld important information that poses a community-relevant threat.

Study 4

In Study 3, we examined whether disclosing prosocial behavior is associated with moral character judgments through measured motive attributions. Study 4 provides an additional test of one of these motive attribution processes—the perceived motive to inform others. Here, we test this process through moderation by manipulating a theoretically relevant boundary condition: the extent to which the associated threat is relevant to the audience. We focus exclusively on third-party punishment and predict that when unethical behavior presents a threat that is more relevant to the audience, the decision to disclose will generate stronger inferences about the perceived motive to inform others, and stronger moral character evaluations. In contrast, when unethical behavior presents a threat that is less relevant to the audience, disclosure choices will be less diagnostic of the perceived motive to inform others.

Method

Participants

We aimed to collect a sufficiently powered sample (80% power at $\alpha = 0.05$) to identify a small interaction of Cohen's $f = 0.10$. We determined that a sample of 787 would be appropriate using G*Power (Faul et al., 2009). We recruited 839 working adults from the United Kingdom on Prolific to participate in our study for £0.40 in compensation. As preregistered, we excluded 39 participants who failed an attention check (and were directed out of the study before seeing materials). After these exclusions, the final dataset includes 800 participants (51.9% men; 48.0% women; 0.1% did not disclose; $M_{Age} = 41.42$; $SD_{Age} = 12.30$). Our study design was a 2 (Disclosure Strategy: *Disclose* versus *Not Disclose*) × 2 (Threat Relevance: *High* versus *Low*) between-subjects design.

Procedure

We presented participants with a third-party punishment scenario adapted from Martin and colleagues (2019), which involves the confrontation of a bicycle vandal. Participants were then told that the punisher joins a work call with clients the following day, where we manipulated the clients' location. We reasoned that information about the incident would pose a greater threat to clients in the local area than to those not in the local area, since the former are more directly affected by the presence of a vandal. Thus, in the *High* Threat Relevance condition, participants read that clients on the call are located in the surrounding area, while in the *Low* Threat Relevance condition, clients are located in another country. We also orthogonally manipulated whether the punisher chooses to tell the clients about the incident the previous day (*Disclose*) or chooses not to tell them (*Not Disclose*) once he connects to the call.

Participants then evaluated the actor's moral character using the same eight-item measure as in Studies 2–3 ($\alpha = 0.95$), the actor's perceived motive to inform others using the same five-item scale as Studies 1 and 3 ($\alpha = 0.81$), and the actor's perceived motive to self-promote using the same five-item scale as Studies 1 and 3 ($\alpha = 0.96$). Participants also completed a disclosure strategy manipulation check (same as Studies 1–3), and a threat relevance manipulation check ("to what extent is the incident that happened last night relevant to the clients' daily lives"; 5-point scale; 1 = *not at all*, 5 = *extremely*).

Results

Manipulation Checks

Disclosure Strategy Manipulation Check. A two-way Disclosure Strategy × Threat Relevance ANOVA predicting the disclosure strategy manipulation check yielded a significant main effect of Disclosure Strategy, $F(1, 796) = 1{,}404.44$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $f = 1.33$, consistent with the intent of the manipulation. Participants in the *Disclose* condition agreed more with the statement that the actor had told others about the incident compared to participants in the *Not Disclose* condition ($M_{Disclose} = 4.04$, $SD_{Disclose} = 1.20$ versus $M_{NotDisclose} = 1.29$, $SD_{NotDisclose} = 0.84$).

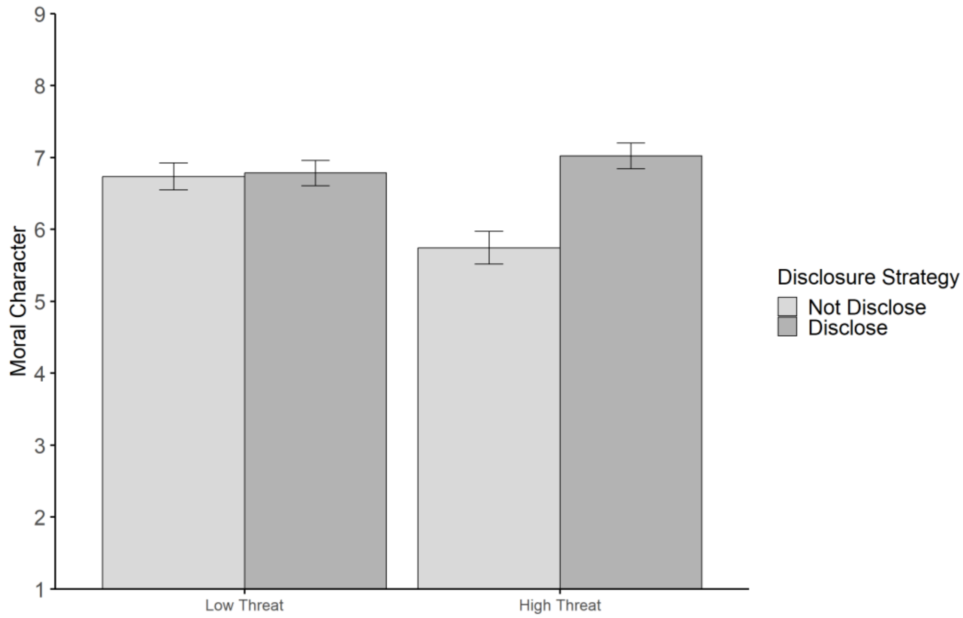
Threat Relevance Manipulation Check. A two-way Disclosure Strategy × Threat Relevance ANOVA predicting the Threat Relevance manipulation check yielded a significant main effect of Threat Relevance, $F(1, 796) = 156.85$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $f = 0.44$, consistent with the intent of the manipulation. Participants in the *High* Threat Relevance condition were more likely to state that the incident would be relevant to the audience compared to participants in the *Low* Threat Relevance condition ($M_{HighThreat}$ = 2.85, $SD_{HighThreat}$ = 1.10 versus $M_{LowThreat}$ = 1.89, $SD_{LowThreat}$ = 1.09).

Moral Character

A two-way Disclosure Strategy × Threat Relevance ANOVA (see *Figure 4*) predicting moral character identified a significant interaction effect, $F(1, 796) = 39.15$, $p < .001$, Cohen's f = 0.22. Planned contrasts within each of the Threat Relevance conditions revealed that, within the *High* Threat Relevance condition, participants ascribed higher moral character to the actor in the *Disclose* condition compared to the *Not Disclose* condition, $t(796) = 9.19$, $p < .001$, Cohen's d = 0.92 ($M_{Disclose}$ = 7.02, $SD_{Disclose}$ = 1.29 versus $M_{NotDisclose}$ = 5.74, $SD_{NotDisclose}$ = 1.63). However, within the *Low* Threat Relevance condition, there was no significant difference across disclosure strategy conditions, $t(796) = 0.34$, $p = .734$, Cohen's d = 0.03 ($M_{Disclose}$ = 6.78, $SD_{Disclose}$ = 1.27 versus $M_{\text{Not}Disclose}$ = 6.74, $SD_{NotDisclose}$ = 1.36).

Figure 4

The Effect of Threat Relevance and Disclosure Strategy on Moral Character (Study 4)



Note. Error bars represent 95% confidence intervals.

Perceived Motive to Inform Others

A two-way Disclosure Strategy × Threat Relevance ANOVA predicting perceived motive to inform others showed a significant interaction, $F(1, 796) = 149.03$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $f = 0.43$. These results revealed that in the *High* Threat Relevance condition, disclosing led participants to report that the actor was more motivated to inform others than when they did not disclose, $t(796) = 22.17$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 2.22$ ($M_{Disclose} = 5.06$, $SD_{Disclose} = 1.12$ versus $M_{NotDisclose} = 2.72$, $SD_{NotDisclose} = 1.06$). This effect was still present in the *Low* Threat Relevance condition, but it was smaller, $t(796) = 4.91$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 0.49$ ($M_{Disclose} = 3.75$, $SD_{Disclose} = 1.17$ versus $M_{NotDisclose} = 3.24$, $SD_{NotDisclose} = 0.84$).

Perceived Motive to Self-Promote

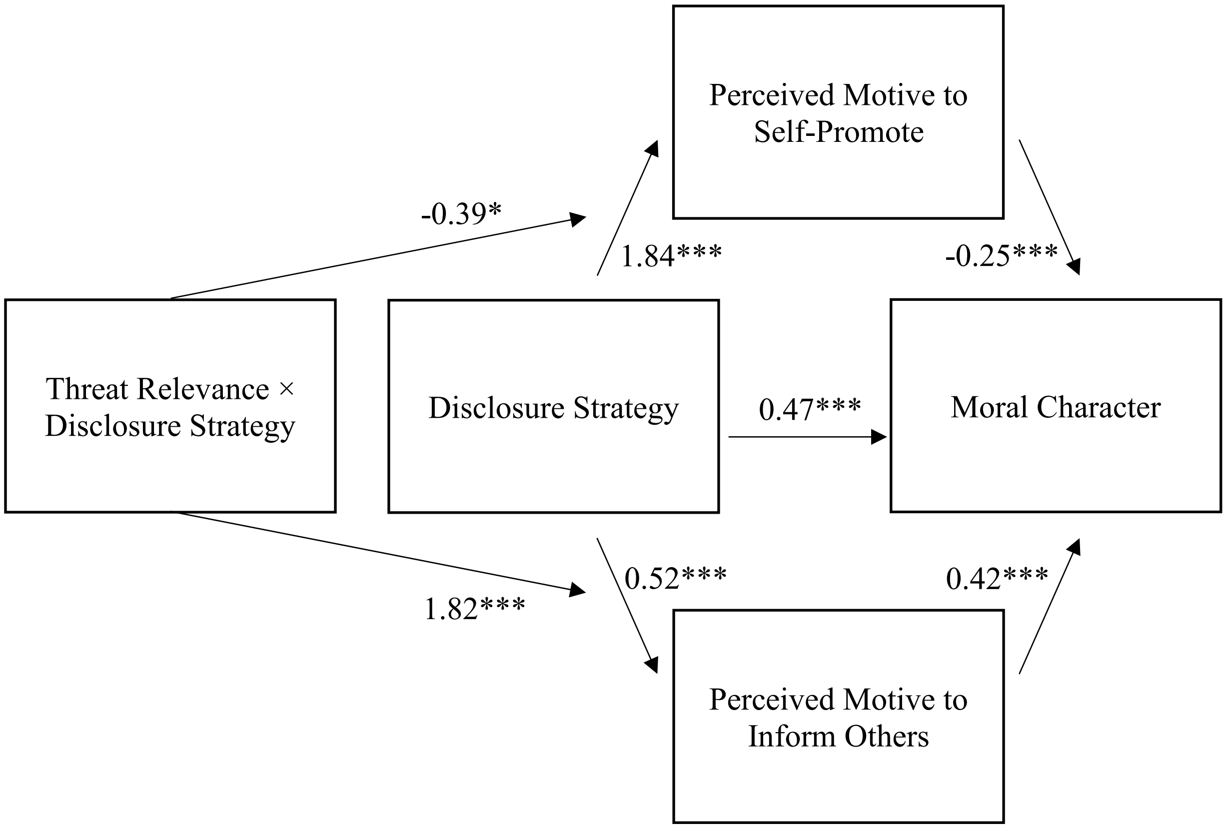
A two-way Disclosure Strategy × Threat Relevance ANOVA predicting perceived motive to self-promote showed a significant interaction, $F(1, 796) = 4.88$, $p = .027$, Cohen's $f = 0.08$, highlighting that the effect of disclosing (versus not disclosing) on perceptions of self-promotion was stronger (i.e., more positive) in the *Low* Threat Relevance condition, $t(796) = 14.55$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 1.45$ ($M_{Disclose} = 4.26$, $SD_{Disclose} = 1.43$ versus $M_{NotDisclose} = 2.43$, $SD_{NotDisclose} = 1.01$) compared to the *High* Threat Relevance condition, $t(796) = 11.42$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 1.14$ ($M_{Disclose} = 3.84$, $SD_{Disclose} = 1.38$ versus $M_{NotDisclose} = 2.40$, $SD_{NotDisclose} = 1.18$).

Indirect Effects

Lastly, we examined whether the effect of Disclosure Strategy on perceived moral character was mediated by perceived motives to self-promote and inform others, and whether this mediation was moderated by Threat Relevance condition. We used Hayes' PROCESS Macro Model 7 (Hayes, 2017; see *Figure 5*). Using 20,000 bootstrapped samples, we found significant indices of moderated mediation (perceived motive to self-promote path: $b = 0.10$, $SE = 0.05$, 95% CI [0.01, 0.20]; perceived motive to inform others path: $b = 0.76$, $SE = 0.10$, 95% CI [0.57, 0.97]).

These moderated mediation results indicated a significant indirect effect through both mediators. However, the negative indirect effect through perceived motive to self-promote was stronger in the *Low* Threat Relevance condition ($b = -0.46$, $SE = 0.08$, 95% CI [-0.61, -0.30]) compared to the *High* Threat Relevance condition ($b = -0.36$, $SE = 0.06$, 95% CI [-0.49, -0.24]). In contrast, the positive indirect effect through perceived motive to inform others was stronger in the *High* Threat Relevance condition ($b = 0.98$, $SE = 0.11$, 95% CI [0.76, 1.20]) compared to the *Low* Threat Relevance condition ($b = 0.22$, $SE = 0.05$, 95% CI [0.13, 0.32]).

Figure 5
Moderated Mediation Results (Hayes PROCESS Model 7; Study 4)



Note. Values represent unstandardized beta coefficients.
*** $p < .001$. * $p < .05$.

Discussion

Study 4 focused on third-party punishment to provide a direct test of the perceived motive to inform others mechanism. Specifically, we manipulated threat relevance and showed that lower threat relevance reduces the strength of the indirect effect of disclosing third-party punishment (versus not disclosing) on moral character evaluations. This is consistent with our hypothesis that third-party punishment disclosure is not uniformly seen to be driven by a perceived motive to inform others, but rather that this is especially likely when audiences can make meaningful use of the disclosed information. These findings highlight that the reputational implications of third-party punishment disclosure depend, in part, on whether observers see the disclosure as communicating a relevant threat.

Study 5

Study 5 provides an integrated test of our theoretical account. Across previous studies, we compared helping and third-party punishment using different background scenarios. As a result, an alternative explanation is that the observed effects may have arisen from differences across these scenarios rather than the type of prosocial behavior. To address this concern, Study 5 employs a single background scenario and manipulates whether the actor responds by helping the victims or punishing the perpetrator. This design helps us isolate whether the moral reputation consequences of disclosure choices depend on the type of prosocial response itself (i.e., helping versus third-party punishment).

Study 5 also builds directly on Study 4 by manipulating the extent to which the threat conveyed through disclosure is relevant to the audience. Our theory predicts that as information about surrounding incidents conveys threats that are more relevant, observers will be increasingly likely to infer that disclosure choices are linked to a perceived motive to inform others. Critically, we predict this will be true *both* when the response to a surrounding incident is helping and when the response is third-party punishment.

Thus, Study 5 uses a 2 (Prosocial Behavior: *TPP* versus *Help*) × 2 (Disclosure Strategy: *Disclose* versus *Not Disclose*) × 2 (Threat Relevance: *High* versus *Low*) between-subjects design. Our theorizing and preregistration plan focused on two distinct interaction effects within this design. First, consistent with Studies 1–3, we predicted a Prosocial Behavior × Disclosure Strategy interaction: disclosure should be less damaging to perceived moral character following third-party punishment than following helping. This is because disclosing third-party punishment (versus not disclosing) should be less diagnostic of a perceived self-promotion motive than disclosing helping (versus not disclosing). Second, consistent with Study 4, we predicted a Threat Relevance × Disclosure Strategy interaction: disclosing (versus not disclosing) should be more positive for perceived moral character when the information conveys more relevant threats to the audience than when it conveys less relevant threats. This should be true across prosocial behavior conditions.

In addition to perceived moral character, we measure perceived motives to self-promote and to inform others. Study 5 therefore offers a comprehensive test of our account by examining, within a single design, how disclosure affects moral reputation through the joint influence of perceived motives to self-promote and inform others.

Method

Participants

Our key prediction concerned two distinct interaction effects. To ensure joint power of approximately 80% to detect both interactions at $\alpha = 0.05$, we targeted 0.90 power for each individual interaction. Because these two interactions are orthogonal in a balanced 2 × 2 × 2 between-subjects design, we treated their tests as statistically independent for the purposes of the joint power calculation. We conducted power analyses for a small effect of Cohen's $f = 0.10$ per interaction using G*Power (Faul et al., 2009). This analysis indicated that a total sample of 1,050 participants would provide 0.90 power to detect an effect of this magnitude at 0.05 significance for each interaction (thus providing approximately 0.80 joint power to detect both interactions). We recruited 1,079 adults from the United Kingdom on Prolific to participate in our study for £0.40 in compensation. As preregistered, we excluded 25 participants who failed an attention check (and were directed out of our study before seeing materials). We also excluded 16 participants for providing incomplete study measures. After exclusions, the final dataset includes 1,038 participants (51.9% women; 47.4% men; 0.3% preferred not to say; 0.4% did not disclose; M_{Age} = 44.67; SD_{Age} = 12.76).

Procedure

Participants read a scenario about a man who often intentionally throws garbage into people's front yards, frustrating members of the residential community in a neighborhood called Riverside. In the *Help* condition, participants read that one evening, Jeff (the prosocial actor) clears up the mess that this perpetrator has left. In the *TPP* condition, participants instead read that one evening, Jeff confronts the perpetrator, shouting that throwing garbage in people's front yards is unacceptable.

Next, in the *Disclose* condition, participants read that when Jeff gets home, he logs into Facebook and posts about his prosocial behavior, explaining that he either cleaned up (*Help*) or confronted the man (*TPP*). In the *Not Disclose* condition, participants read that Jeff posts about a lovely sunset over Riverside that evening and never tells anyone what he did.

In the *High* Threat Relevance condition, participants read that Jeff's post was in a private group called "Riverside Locals" with around 400 members. In the *Low* Threat Relevance condition, participants read that Jeff's post was in a private group that is instead called "FIAT 500 Lovers" with around 400 members.

Finally, participants provided measures of moral character using the same scale as Studies 2–4 (α = 0.95), perceived motive to self-promote (α = 0.97), and perceived motive to inform others (α = 0.83) using the same scales as Studies 1, 3, and 4. Participants also completed a prosocial behavior manipulation check (same as Studies 1–4), a disclosure strategy manipulation check (same as Studies 1–4), and a threat relevance manipulation check (same as Study 4).

Results

Manipulation Checks

Prosocial Behavior Manipulation Check. A three-way ANOVA predicting the prosocial behavior manipulation check yielded a significant effect of Prosocial Behavior, $F(1, 1{,}030) = 1{,}067.85$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $f = 1.02$, indicating that our manipulation was successful. Participants reported higher scores in the *Help* condition compared to the *TPP* condition ($M_{Help} = 6.23$, $SD_{Help} = 1.16$ versus $M_{TPP} = 3.68$, $SD_{TPP} = 1.34$).

Disclosure Strategy Manipulation Check. A three-way ANOVA predicting the disclosure strategy manipulation check yielded a significant main effect of Disclosure Strategy, $F(1, 1{,}030) = 1{,}925.88$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $f = 1.37$, confirming that our manipulation was successful. Participants reported higher scores in the *Disclose* condition compared to the *Not Disclose* condition ($M_{Disclose} = 4.05$, $SD_{Disclose} = 1.31$ versus $M_{NotDisclose} = 1.23$, $SD_{NotDisclose} = 0.65$).

Threat Relevance Manipulation Check. A three-way ANOVA predicting the threat relevance manipulation check yielded a significant main effect of Threat Relevance, $F(1, 1{,}030) = 1{,}173.05$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $f = 1.07$, indicating that our manipulation was successful. Participants reported higher scores in the *High* Threat Relevance condition compared to the *Low* Threat Relevance condition ($M_{HighThreat} = 3.98$, $SD_{HighThreat} = 0.91$ versus $M_{LowThreat} = 1.84$, $SD_{LowThreat} = 1.11$).

Moral Character

Our theorizing makes two predictions about the pattern of results within our 2 (Prosocial Behavior) × 2 (Disclosure Strategy) × 2 (Threat Relevance) three-way design. First, we predicted that Disclosure Strategy would have a more negative effect on perceived moral character in the context of *Help* versus *TPP*. Second, we predicted that Disclosure Strategy would have a more positive effect on perceived moral character in the *High* versus *Low* Threat Relevance condition.

We ran a three-way ANOVA to examine these predictions (see *Table 1* and *Figure 6*). First, we examined whether perceived moral character following disclosure differed between helping and third-party punishment. To test this, we examined the Prosocial Behavior × Disclosure Strategy interaction, which was significant, $F(1, 1{,}030) = 11.74$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $f = 0.11$. Specifically, disclosure reduced moral character judgments in the *Help* condition ($M_{Disclose} = 7.24$, $SD_{Disclose} = 1.12$ versus $M_{NotDisclose} = 7.49$, $SD_{NotDisclose} = 1.40$), $t(1{,}030) = -2.00$, $p = .045$, Cohen's $d = -0.18$, while it increased such judgments in the *TPP* condition ($M_{Disclose} = 6.81$, $SD_{Disclose} = 1.36$ versus $M_{NotDisclose} = 6.46$, $SD_{NotDisclose} = 1.74$), $t(1{,}030) = 2.84$, $p = .005$, Cohen's $d = 0.25$.

Next, we examined whether the reputation consequences of disclosure depend on threat relevance, as in Study 4. To test this, we examined the Disclosure Strategy × Threat Relevance interaction. Contrary to our predictions, this was not significant, $F(1, 1{,}030) = 2.67$, $p = .103$, Cohen's $f = 0.05$, thereby failing to provide clear evidence that threat relevance moderated the effect of disclosure on moral character. Nevertheless, to characterize the pattern of means, we conducted non-preregistered exploratory tests of the Disclosure Strategy × Threat Relevance interaction separately for the *Help* and *TPP* conditions.

Within the *Help* condition, the Disclosure Strategy × Threat Relevance interaction was significant, $F(1, 1{,}030) = 6.03$, $p = .014$, Cohen's $f = 0.08$. Specifically, in the *Low* Threat Relevance condition, disclosing led to lower moral character ascriptions versus not disclosing, $t(1{,}030) = -3.14$, $p = .002$, Cohen's $d = -0.39$ ($M_{Disclose} = 6.91$, $SD_{Disclose} = 1.17$ versus $M_{NotDisclose} = 7.46$, $SD_{NotDisclose} = 1.40$). In the *High* Threat Relevance condition, disclosing did not have a significant effect on perceived moral character, $t(1{,}030) = 0.32$, $p = .748$, Cohen's $d = 0.04$ ($M_{Disclose} = 7.58$, $SD_{Disclose} = 0.97$ versus $M_{NotDisclose} = 7.53$, $SD_{NotDisclose} = 1.40$).

Within the *TPP* condition, however, the Disclosure Strategy × Threat Relevance interaction was not significant, $F(1, 1{,}030) = 0.02$, $p = .882$, Cohen's $f = 0.00$. In the *Low* Threat Relevance condition, disclosing led to higher moral character ratings than not disclosing, $t(1{,}030) = 2.12$, $p = .035$, Cohen's $d = 0.26$ ($M_{Disclose} = 6.75$, $SD_{Disclose} = 1.30$ versus $M_{NotDisclose} = 6.38$, $SD_{NotDisclose} = 1.75$). In the *High* Threat Relevance condition, disclosing did not significantly change moral character perceptions relative to not disclosing, $t(1{,}030) = 1.91$, $p = .057$, Cohen's $d = 0.24$ ($M_{Disclose} = 6.87$, $SD_{Disclose} = 1.41$ versus $M_{NotDisclose} = 6.54$, $SD_{NotDisclose} = 1.73$).

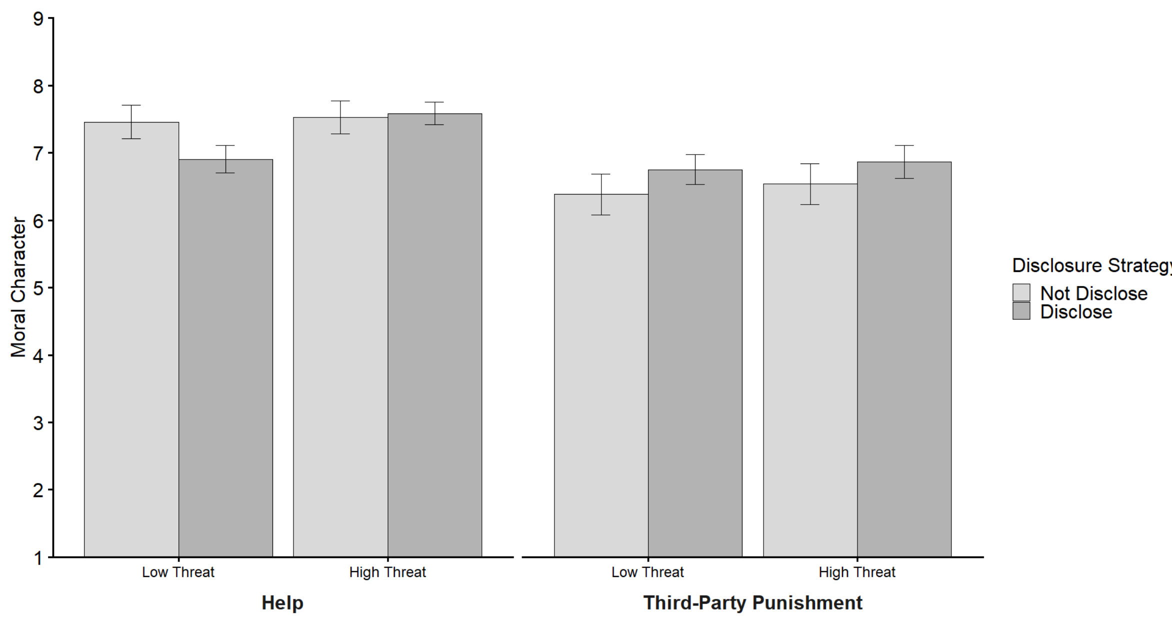
Table 1
ANOVA Results (Study 5)

Dependent Variable and Independent Variables	df	*F*	*p*	Cohen's *f*
Moral Character				
Prosocial Behavior	1, 1,030	70.02***	< .001	0.26
Disclosure Strategy	1, 1,030	0.35	.555	0.02
Threat Relevance	1, 1,030	8.44**	.004	0.09
Prosocial Behavior × Disclosure Strategy	1, 1,030	11.74***	< .001	0.11
Prosocial Behavior × Threat Relevance	1, 1,030	1.84	.176	0.04
Disclosure Strategy × Threat Relevance	1, 1,030	2.67	.103	0.05
Prosocial Behavior × Disclosure Strategy × Threat Relevance	1, 1,030	3.40	.066	0.06
Perceived Motive to Self-Promote				
Prosocial Behavior	1, 1,030	13.98***	< .001	0.12
Disclosure Strategy	1, 1,030	513.89***	< .001	0.71
Threat Relevance	1, 1,030	18.19***	< .001	0.13
Prosocial Behavior × Disclosure Strategy	1, 1,030	60.65***	< .001	0.24
Prosocial Behavior × Threat Relevance	1, 1,030	0.29	.591	0.02
Disclosure Strategy × Threat Relevance	1, 1,030	4.42*	.036	0.07
Prosocial Behavior × Disclosure Strategy × Threat Relevance	1, 1,030	4.38*	.037	0.07
Perceived Motive to Inform Others				
Prosocial Behavior	1, 1,030	2.93	.087	0.05
Disclosure Strategy	1, 1,030	779.93***	< .001	0.87
Threat Relevance	1, 1,030	122.65***	< .001	0.35
Prosocial Behavior × Disclosure Strategy	1, 1,030	0.59	.443	0.02
Prosocial Behavior × Threat Relevance	1, 1,030	1.65	.199	0.04
Disclosure Strategy × Threat Relevance	1, 1,030	186.07***	< .001	0.43
Prosocial Behavior × Disclosure Strategy × Threat Relevance	1, 1,030	0.10	.747	0.01

Note. *** $p < .001$; ** $p < .01$; * $p < .05$.

Figure 6

The Effect of Threat Relevance and Disclosure Strategy by Prosocial Behavior on Moral Character (Study 5)



Note. Error bars represent 95% confidence intervals.

Perceived Motive to Self-Promote

We had two key predictions for perceived motive to self-promote. First, we predicted that those who disclosed their prosocial behavior would be seen as more self-promotional than those who did not, consistent with existing work (e.g., Berman et al., 2015) and our findings in earlier studies. Second, and consistent with our earlier findings, we predicted that disclosing (versus not disclosing) *Help* would show a larger difference in perceived motive to self-promote compared to disclosing (versus not disclosing) *TPP*.

To test these predictions, we ran a three-way ANOVA predicting perceived motive to self-promote (see *Table 1*). Consistent with our predictions, we found a significant main effect of Disclosure Strategy, $F(1, 1{,}030) = 513.89$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $f = 0.71$, showing that those who disclosed were seen as more self-promotional than those who did not disclose ($M_{Disclose}$ = 4.73, $SD_{Disclose}$ = 1.37 versus $M_{NotDisclose}$ = 2.85, $SD_{NotDisclose}$ = 1.43).

Also consistent with our predictions, we found a significant Prosocial Behavior × Disclosure Strategy interaction, $F(1, 1{,}030) = 60.65$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $f = 0.24$. Contrasts revealed that in the *Help* condition, disclosing led to higher perceived motive to self-promote than not disclosing, $t(1{,}030) = 21.51$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 1.89$ ($M_{Disclose}$ = 4.89, $SD_{Disclose}$ = 1.34 versus $M_{NotDisclose}$ = 2.37, $SD_{NotDisclose}$ = 1.24). The effect of disclosing was weaker (i.e., less positive) in the *TPP* condition, $t(1{,}030) = 10.53$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 0.92$ ($M_{Disclose}$ = 4.56, $SD_{Disclose}$ = 1.37 versus $M_{NotDisclose}$ = 3.32, $SD_{NotDisclose}$ = 1.44). These results therefore replicate the pattern that emerged in earlier studies by showing that disclosing (versus not disclosing) *TPP* is less diagnostic of perceived motive to self-promote than disclosing (versus not disclosing) *Help*.

Perceived Motive to Inform Others

We had two key predictions for the perceived motive to inform others. First, we predicted that respondents would believe the prosocial actor was more motivated to inform others when the actor disclosed than when the actor did not disclose, since it is only possible to inform through disclosure. Replicating findings from Study 4, we further predicted that the difference in perceived motive to inform others between disclosing and not disclosing would be greater when the information revealed a more relevant threat to the audience.

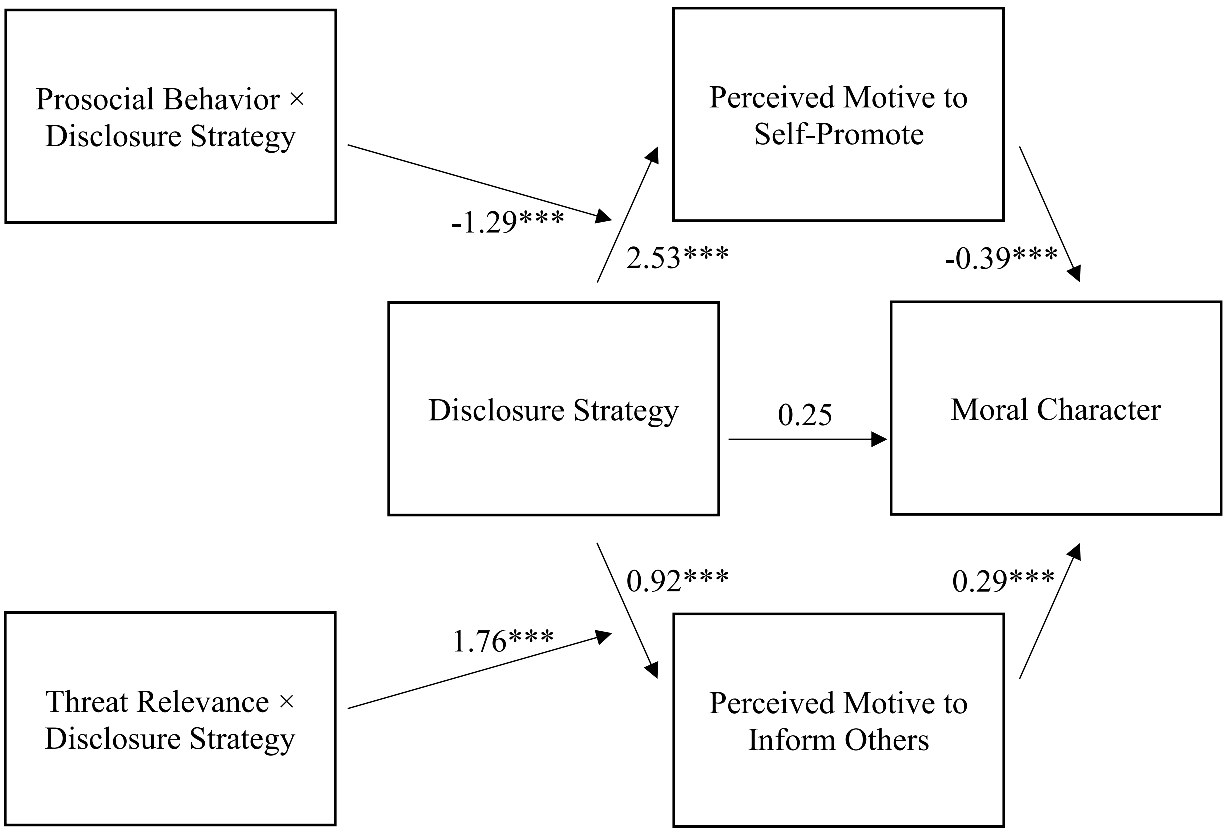
To test these predictions, we ran a three-way ANOVA predicting perceived motive to inform others (see *Table 1*). We found a significant main effect of Disclosure Strategy, $F(1, 1{,}030) = 779.93$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $f = 0.87$, such that prosocial actors were seen as more motivated to inform others when they disclosed versus did not ($M_{Disclose}$ = 4.89, $SD_{Disclose}$ = 1.37 versus $M_{NotDisclose}$ = 3.09, $SD_{NotDisclose}$ = 0.97).

Next, as predicted, we found a significant Disclosure Strategy × Threat Relevance interaction, $F(1, 1{,}030) = 186.07$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $f = 0.43$. Contrasts revealed that disclosing led to higher perceived motive to inform others in the *Low* Threat Relevance condition, $t(1{,}030) = 10.08$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 0.89$ ($M_{Disclose}$ = 4.09, $SD_{Disclose}$ = 1.26 versus $M_{NotDisclose}$ = 3.17, $SD_{NotDisclose}$ = 0.91). This effect was stronger in the *High* Threat Relevance condition, $t(1{,}030) = 29.45$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 2.58$ ($M_{Disclose}$ = 5.69, $SD_{Disclose}$ = 0.93 versus $M_{NotDisclose}$ = 3.01, $SD_{NotDisclose}$ = 1.02).

Indirect Effects

Finally, we examined whether the effect of Disclosure Strategy on perceived moral character was mediated by perceived motive to self-promote and perceived motive to inform others, and whether these indirect pathways were moderated by Prosocial Behavior and Threat Relevance, respectively, using structural equation modeling (see *Figure 7*). Using 20,000 bootstrapped samples, we found significant indices of moderated mediation (perceived motive to self-promote path: b = 0.50, SE = 0.08, 95% CI [0.35, 0.66]; perceived motive to inform others path: b = 0.52, *SE* = 0.08, *95% CI* [0.37, 0.67]). These moderated mediation results indicate that the indirect effects of Disclosure Strategy on moral character judgments via perceived motive to self-promote and perceived motive to inform others were significantly different depending on Prosocial Behavior condition and Threat Relevance condition, respectively. Disclosing had a stronger negative indirect effect on perceived moral character via perceived motive to self-promote in the *Help* condition (b = -0.98, *SE* = 0.10, 95% CI [-1.18, -0.79]) compared to the *TPP* condition (b = -0.48, *SE* = 0.06, 95% CI [-0.61, -0.36]). Independently, disclosing had a stronger positive indirect effect on perceived moral character via perceived motive to inform others in the *High* Threat Relevance condition (b = 0.79, SE = 0.11, 95% CI [0.58, 1.00]) compared to the *Low* Threat Relevance condition (b = 0.27, SE = 0.05, 95% CI [0.18, 0.37]).

Figure 7
Moderated Mediation Results (Structural Equation Model; Study 5)



Note. Values represent unstandardized path coefficients.
*** $p < .001$.

Discussion

Study 5 provides a stringent test of our theoretical account by manipulating prosocial behavior, disclosure strategy, and threat relevance using a single background scenario. The results offered partial support for our theorizing.

First, Study 5 replicated a central pattern from the earlier studies—disclosing was seen as more self-promotional than not disclosing, and this effect was stronger for helping than for third-party punishment. Second, Study 5 independently supported the perceived motive to inform others pathway. Respondents inferred a stronger motive to inform others when actors disclosed—and this difference was substantially larger when the information conveyed relevant threats to the audience. Importantly, this pattern emerged for both helping and third-party punishment, suggesting that this mechanism is not unique to punishment. Thus, actors may somewhat benefit from helping disclosure when they convey threatening information about preceding unethical behavior.

Mediation results were consistent with our theoretical account. Disclosing had a stronger negative indirect effect on moral reputation via the perceived motive to self-promote in the *Help* condition than in the *TPP* condition, and a stronger positive indirect effect via the perceived motive to inform others in the *High* Threat condition than in the *Low* Threat condition.

However, contrary to our preregistered prediction, threat relevance did not significantly moderate the effect of disclosure on moral character ascriptions across both forms of prosocial behavior. Although Study 4 found this moderation for third-party punishment, Study 5 found it only for helping. Thus, Study 5 supported the predicted effect of threat relevance on perceived motive to inform others but provided only partial support for its effect on moral reputation.

General Discussion

The present research examines whether disclosing prosocial behavior is always reputationally costly, or whether the consequences depend on the type of prosocial act disclosed and specific contextual features surrounding those acts. We compared third-party punishment to helping as two distinct forms of prosocial behavior and predicted that disclosure carries a smaller moral reputation penalty for third-party punishment than for helping.

Across five preregistered experiments, we showed that disclosure decisions about third-party punishment, compared to disclosure decisions about helping, are less diagnostic of a *self-promotion* motive and more diagnostic of a motive *to inform others* about community-relevant threats. These findings identify the perceived motive to inform others as an overlooked motive attribution that can enhance, rather than undermine, moral reputation when actors disclose their own prosocial behavior. We further show that, as the context surrounding a prosocial act conveys threats that are more relevant to audiences, disclosure of both third-party punishment and helping is increasingly attributed to the motive to inform others.

Theoretical Contributions

The present research advances theory in at least three ways. First, we qualify the assumption that disclosing prosocial behavior is costly for moral reputation. Prior work has primarily examined disclosure in the context of helping, where actors who share their good deeds are often judged as self-promotional (Berman et al., 2015; Carlson et al., 2022; De Freitas et al., 2019). We show that this disclosure penalty does not apply uniformly across prosocial acts. Instead, the moral reputation consequences of disclosure depend on the kind of prosocial behavior being disclosed.

Second, we extend this literature by integrating third-party punishment into theories of prosocial behavior disclosure. Helping tends to provide unambiguously positive signals about an actor's traits, whereas third-party punishment conveys a more mixed profile: punishers may appear principled and trustworthy (e.g., Jordan et al., 2016), but also dominant, aggressive, or threatening (e.g., Raihani & Bshary, 2015a). We show that this difference in trait signal structure shapes how disclosure is subsequently perceived—such that third-party punishment disclosure (versus nondisclosure) is perceived as less diagnostic of self-promotion. This suggests that theories of prosocial behavior disclosure must account for variation in the trait signals inherent to the underlying prosocial acts.

Third, we identify the perceived motive to inform others as a distinct attribution that shapes reactions to prosocial behavior disclosure. Existing work has emphasized self-promotion as the primary motive attribution that drives disclosure penalties on moral reputation. We show that observers also infer the extent to which disclosing prosocial behavior is motivated by a desire to inform others, particularly when disclosure reveals information that represents a relevant threat to the audience. Moral reputation appears to be shaped by the joint influence of these two motive attributions: disclosing prosocial behavior decreases moral reputation to the extent that it signals self-promotion but increases moral reputation to the extent that it signals a perceived motive to inform others. This dual-inference account provides a more complete explanation of when disclosing prosocial behavior undermines moral reputation, and when it does not.

Practical Implications

Our findings have implications for the ways in which individuals may manage decisions about disclosing their prosocial acts. First, decisions about disclosing must consider the type of prosocial behavior being disclosed, because the reputational risks are not uniform across these prosocial acts. Second, disclosure decisions must consider the relevance and importance of the contextual information conveyed by disclosure. Thus, when disclosure reveals community-relevant threats (e.g., norm violations that pose danger to that specific audience), disclosure may be more beneficial for moral reputation, whereas withholding this information may carry reputational risk, particularly when others expect to be informed. While actors may assume that modesty about prosocial behavior is normative, they must also recognize that other norms sometimes dictate a need for disclosure. Recognizing this distinction is critical—enabling actors to navigate when disclosing prosocial behavior is rewarded versus penalized.

Limitations and Future Directions

The present findings are not without their limitations (see *Table 2*). Across Studies 4–5, we found consistent evidence that disclosure is more likely to be attributed to a motive to inform others when the disclosed information conveys a more relevant threat to the audience. However, the interaction of disclosure and threat relevance predicted perceived moral character less consistently. In Study 4, threat relevance moderated the effect of third-party punishment disclosure (versus nondisclosure) on perceived moral character. In Study 5, by contrast, this interaction was not significant across prosocial behaviors, although it did emerge specifically for helping. Future research should examine why threat relevance sometimes translates into differences in moral reputation and sometimes does not. For example, future studies could vary the severity, proximity, or recurrence of the underlying threat.

Additionally, our studies relied on experimental vignettes and participants' evaluations of unfamiliar actors. This approach allowed us to isolate causal effects, but participants' evaluations may not fully capture how they would respond to disclosure in real-world settings, particularly in the context of ongoing relationships. Future research should consider whether features of relationships (e.g., power relationships; Emerson, 1962) may impact these results. Moreover, we operationalized third-party punishment as the direct confrontation of perpetrators through verbal reprimand; however, future research should assess whether punishment type (e.g., physical confrontation) and other features of punishment (e.g., severity) moderate our findings.

Future research should also examine whether broader features of these prosocial acts shape the reputational effects of disclosure. Prosocial behavior varies along a variety of dimensions, including the costliness of the act, the benefits provided to others, and the identifiability of the beneficiary. These and other features may alter whether disclosing—or failing to disclose—prosocial behavior is met with suspicion, seen as appropriate, or even viewed as normatively expected. Examining these features may further advance our understanding of the effects of disclosing prosocial behavior on reputation.

Finally, we conducted our studies using participants from online panels in the United Kingdom, and results may not generalize to other populations, particularly non-WEIRD populations (Western, Educated, Industrialized, Rich, Democratic; Henrich et al., 2010). We suggest that future research should examine whether demographic and cultural factors impact our results.

Table 2
Assessment of Limitations

Dimension	Assessment
Internal validity	
Is the phenomenon diagnosed with experimental methods?	Yes.
Is the phenomenon diagnosed with longitudinal methods?	No.
Were the manipulations validated with manipulation checks, pretest data, or outcome data?	Yes, manipulations were validated with manipulation checks in all studies.
What possible artifacts were ruled out?	We used real-world incidents, as well as multiple hypothetical vignettes involving third-party punishment and helping others in our studies—drawing on scenarios from prior literature, designing new scenarios, and generating novel scenarios using ChatGPT-4o (OpenAI, 2024)—which partially addresses scenario-specific artifacts.
Statistical validity	
Was the statistical power at least 80%?	All our main studies were preregistered, and we determined sample sizes a priori to detect the predicted effects with 0.80 power.
Was the reliability of the dependent measure established in this publication or elsewhere in the literature?	Yes, we report αs for all dependent measures in our studies, all of which were greater than 0.70 in our main studies.
If covariates are used, have the researchers ensured they are not affected by the experimental manipulation before including them in	Not applicable, we did not use covariates in our studies.

comparisons across experimental groups?	
Were the distributional properties of the variables examined and did the variables have sufficient variability to verify effects?	Yes, we inspected distributional properties of all dependent variables and validated that they exhibited adequate variability, showing no evidence of skewness, kurtosis, or floor/ceiling effects that would undermine detection of effects.
Construct validity	
Was convergent or divergent validity of new dependent measures assessed?	We used established scales for our dependent measures. The only exception is the *perceived motive to inform others* measure used in Studies 1, 3, 4, and 5, which we developed for this manuscript. We did not formally assess convergent and divergent validity of this scale.
Generalizability to different methods	
Were different experimental manipulations used?	Yes, we used different prosocial behavior scenarios, manipulations of disclosing (e.g., posts on social media, bringing it up in conversation with colleagues) and not disclosing (e.g., posts about weekend plans on social media, chooses not to bring it up in conversation with colleagues), and different manipulations of threat relevance (e.g., discloses to clients in another country, discloses on different social media groups).
Generalizability to field settings	
Was the phenomenon assessed in a field setting?	No.
Are the methods artificial?	Yes, the methods are artificial. We leveraged hypothetical vignettes in our studies that only operationalized third-party punishment using the direct confrontation of perpetrators. Participants neither observed these incidents nor interacted with the actors, while their responses did not take place in the context of ongoing relationships. We also relied on participants' self-reported judgments. Together, this implies that participants' responses in our studies may not fully represent their real-world responses to these incidents.
Generalizability to times and populations	

Are the results generalizable to different years and historic periods?	No, this was not tested.
Are the results generalizable across populations (e.g., different ages, cultures, or nationalities)?	We conducted our studies with adults from the United Kingdom using online panels. We cannot rule out that results may differ in other populations, particularly non-WEIRD populations (Western, Educated, Industrialized, Rich, and Democratic).
Theoretical limitations	
What are the main theoretical limitations?	We used *measured-mediation* designs to elaborate the psychological mechanisms that mediate our central effect; however, we did not manipulate these mediators using a *causal chain* design (Spencer et al., 2005).

Conclusion

Prior research has suggested that disclosing one's own prosocial behavior is reputationally costly because it invites inferences of self-promotion. The present research shows that this conclusion is incomplete. Across five preregistered experiments, we demonstrate that disclosure does not carry a single social meaning. Rather, observers interpret disclosure in light of what the underlying prosocial act communicates about the actor's motives. In the case of third-party punishment, disclosure is less readily interpreted as self-promotion and more readily interpreted as an attempt to inform others about community-relevant threats.

More broadly, our findings highlight that observers evaluate actors who disclose prosocial behavior by asking not only whether they disclosed a good deed, but why they chose to do so. The reputational consequences of this disclosure therefore depend not simply on the decision to disclose or not, but on the social meaning of the prosocial act itself.

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Appendix: Vignettes in Studies 1–2

***Help* condition**

- Walking past a community centre, Maria notices a poster for a children's hospital fundraiser. She stops at the donation box and contributes £50.
- On a Saturday morning, David sees a notice about a park clean-up event. He decides to spend his afternoon helping to pick up litter with the organisers.
- Sarah overhears a colleague struggling with a new software program. She offers her expertise and spends her lunch break guiding them through the basics.
- During a storm, Alex notices his neighbour's umbrella has broken. He hands over his spare umbrella, ensuring the neighbour can stay dry.
- Emma sees an elderly woman struggling with her groceries at the supermarket. She steps in to carry the bags to the woman's car.

***TPP* condition**

- Sandra sees a stranger kicking a neighbour's garden gnome. She tells him to stop damaging property, warning him it's unacceptable behaviour.
- Mike watches a passerby throw a drink can onto the pavement. He approaches the person and firmly states that littering harms the environment.
- Emily overhears a man shouting insults at a shop assistant. She steps in, telling him that disrespectful language is not tolerated.
- Tom notices someone cutting in line at the bus stop. He confronts them, insisting they respect the queue and wait their turn.

- Lisa sees a teenager hitting a stray dog with a stick. She intervenes, reprimanding him for mistreating animals and urging him to stop.

Note. These vignettes were written in British English since participants were recruited from the United Kingdom.